

Parental care

Many young animals never see their parents. Instead, they have to look after themselves. But for others, life gets off to a much safer start, thanks to caring parents. These parents protect their young from predators, and often lead their young to food. Some parents go even further, by collecting food for their offspring, or by making it themselves. Usually it is the female that does the caring, or both parents working as a team. But in some animals, such as ostriches and mouthbrooding fish, the male raises the family on his own.



Follow the leader

Once young ostriches have left their nest, they follow their father, who teaches them where to feed. When different families meet, they often join together to form a giant family, or crèche. A crèche can contain more than 50 chicks supervised by a dominant male.



Newly hatched crocodile carried from nest to water

Gentle jaws

Despite their fearsome teeth, female crocodiles are remarkably gentle parents. They bury their eggs in riverside nests and wait nearby for nearly three months until the young are ready to hatch. As soon as the young start to squeak, the mother digs down to the nest and carries the babies to water in her jaws. Instinct prevents her from closing her mouth, so her young are safe.

Full back

Life is a race for young Virginia opossums, because their mother gives birth to more young than she has teats. The strongest, fastest babies find her pouch first and fasten themselves onto a spare teat, where they drink her milk. Once they are around two months old, they leave her pouch and she carries them around on her back.

